

The Seal & Signature Guide

The red seal in the corner is what separates a practice sheet from a finished piece. Here is how to design, order, and place yours like a traditional master.



A painting is not finished when you lift the brush — it is finished when you stamp it.

The small red seal — the **hanko** — is the mark that turns a sheet of practice into a claimed, completed work. It says, quietly and permanently: this is mine, and it is done. Designed and placed well, it is the most professional detail on the page.

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- ◆ How to design your personal hanko — name, artist initials, or chosen kanji
- ◆ Where to order a quality hand-carved seal for under \$20, online and locally
- ◆ Traditional seal placement — and the meaning behind each position
- ◆ How to sign and stamp so your work looks authentic and collector-grade

Designing Your Hanko

A seal carries two decisions: what it says, and how it is cut. Settle the first, then the second.

Your Name in Kanji — *the traditional choice*

Have your name rendered phonetically into kanji, or translated for its meaning. The most personal option, and the classic content for a name seal.

Your Artist Initials — *the simplest choice*

Your Latin initials or a small monogram, carved into the stone. Entirely legitimate, unmistakably yours, and the easiest design to get right.

A Chosen Kanji or Art-Name — *the expressive choice*

Traditional painters took a *gō* — an art-name. Pick one or two kanji whose meaning you want your work to carry: 静 stillness, 風 wind, 心 heart.

THEN, THE FOUR DESIGN CHOICES

SHAPE	Square	The square name seal is the most formal and traditional. Save round or irregular shapes for casual mood seals.
SCRIPT	Seal script	<i>Tensho</i> — the archaic, angular script carvers have used for centuries. It reads instantly as a seal.
STYLE	Red characters	Characters standing in red on a clear ground (<i>shubun</i>) give the clean, classic look a painting wants.
SIZE	1–2 cm	Small. A name seal should sit quietly in the corner and never compete with the painting itself.

Where To Order — Under \$20

A hand-carved seal is a keepsake, not a luxury. Here is how to get a real one — and the paste to use it — without overpaying.

1 A Hand-Carved Stone Seal — *the piece itself*

Send your kanji or initials to a carver and have a soapstone seal cut by hand. Soapstone is soft, inexpensive, and the traditional beginner's stone.

LOOK FOR A carver who works in seal script and cuts a square ~1.5 cm stone.

BUY IT [etsy.com](https://www.etsy.com) > “custom Chinese name chop”

PRICE about \$12–20, hand-carved

2 Red Seal Paste — *what you stamp with*

A small tin of cinnabar (vermilion) seal paste, called *inni*. Thick, oil-based, and slow-drying — a single tin will outlast years of painting.

LOOK FOR A small tin of genuine Chinese/Japanese seal paste — not a stamp pad.

BUY IT [amazon.com](https://www.amazon.com) > “seal paste inni”

PRICE about \$8–12 a tin

3 Carved Locally, While You Wait — *the same-day route*

Many Chinatown stationers and Asian bookshops carve a custom seal on the spot. You watch it cut, and walk out with it the same afternoon.

LOOK FOR Chinatown art shops, or bookstores such as Kinokuniya and Morning Glory.

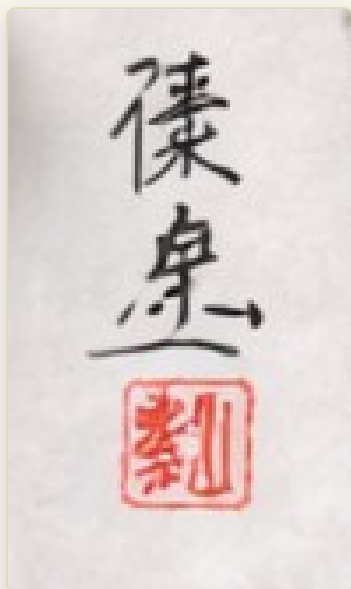
BUY IT In person — bring your kanji or initials written out clearly.

PRICE about \$10–20, carved on site

What to send the carver: your characters or initials written out clearly, the shape (square), the script (seal script), and the size (about 1.5 cm). Ask for **red characters on a clear ground** — the classic look for a name seal — and you will get exactly what a painting wants.

Placement & Meaning

Where the seal sits is never random. Each position has a name, a job, and a meaning the masters held to.



*Signature and name seal,
set into the empty corner*

1 The Signature

Your name, brushed in a slim vertical column in the empty space beside the subject. It reads top to bottom, in the same ink as the painting.

2 The Name Seal

Stamped directly below or beside the signature. This is the formal close — “this work is complete, and it is mine.”

3 The Opening Seal

A small seal set high on the page, diagonally opposite the signature. It “opens” the painting. Optional, and a more advanced touch.

4 The Balancing Seal

Occasionally a seal placed low in the opposite corner — used only to settle a composition that leans heavily to one side.

WHY IT GOES WHERE IT GOES

The seal always sits in **negative space** — never on the subject. Its job is twofold: it **anchors empty space and balances** the painting’s visual weight, and its red is the single deliberate spark of color that completes an all-black-ink work. The seal is the full stop at the end of the sentence.

Signing & Stamping

The seal is the last mark you make — and the one a viewer reads first. These six steps are how to land it cleanly, every time.

- 1 **Sign before you stamp.** With a smaller brush and the same ink, brush your name in a slim vertical column. Keep it modest — it should never rival the painting.
- 2 **Let everything dry first.** Stamp only when the ink is bone-dry — both the painting and the signature. Wet ink and red paste together is a smudge you cannot undo.
- 3 **Load the seal evenly.** Dab the seal face into the paste with small, light touches until the whole face is covered. Never grind it in — that floods the lines.
- 4 **Cushion the paper.** Place a few spare sheets or a felt pad under your work, so the seal presses a clean, full, even impression.
- 5 **Stamp once, with conviction.** Position the seal, press straight down with firm even pressure, give it the slightest rock, and lift straight up. One impression — never re-stamp over it.
- 6 **Test on a scrap first.** Every time, press the loaded seal on spare paper first, until the impression comes out crisp and solid. Then commit to the real piece.

Less is more. One signature and one name seal finishes almost any painting. Resist adding more — a crowd of seals reads as decoration, not authorship. Wipe the seal clean and cap the paste after every use.

Sign it small, stamp it once, and the painting is finally, unmistakably yours.